

9.6 System Restore

System Restore is a useful feature in XP, which wasn't available in earlier Windows versions. This essentially allows you to “roll back” your computer to an earlier, more stable point.

There are a variety of situations in which you might want to use System Restore. You might have made changes to the Registry, which are now causing some programs to not work properly. Or you might have installed a new program that interferes with another program's functionality. You might have made certain system-wide changes via the Control Panel, and you can't figure out how to get your old settings back. In all these situations, all you need to do is roll back your system to an earlier Restore Point.

What are Restore Points? Windows XP continually monitors what's going on in the system, and whenever a major change is happening, Windows “records” the state of the system and stores that state as a “Restore Point” that you can get back to. Such Restore Points are continually being created, but you can create one whenever you like—for example, if you're about to install a major program.



Creating a Restore Point is simple

So why have more than one Restore Point? Imagine when you installed one program A, then installed another program B. Your computer is now malfunctioning. Do you restore it to before you installed B or to before you installed A? Basically, you might not know what has caused your system to malfunction—hence the availability of multiple Restore Points.